Can Morocco Democratise?

What the human-capital data actually say — a synthesis note

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Sources: Barro-Lee v3 (2021) · Wittgenstein Centre WCDE v3.3 · World Bank WDI & Human Capital Index · UNESCO UIS (Feb-2026) · V-Dem v15 · Maddison Project 2023 · OECD PISA 2022 · HCP, RGPH 2024. Ten tables, twelve figures, 144 democratic transitions since 1960.

I. The essential, in one page

The question this note tests is a widely held one in Morocco: **that the country is too poorly educated to sustain a full democratic transition** — that the Korean, Taiwanese or Vietnamese standard of mass education is a precondition Morocco has not met.

The data reject that proposition, and they reject it in a specific, verifiable way.

> **Morocco today is richer than 68 % of all countries at the moment they democratised, and better schooled than 46 % of them. Its under-40s are better schooled than 76 % of them. And Morocco is already 0.17 points *less* democratic than its own income and education predict.**

The education gap is real, but it is not located where intuition places it. It is not a gap in *years* — Morocco is at the historical median. It is a gap in **who holds those years** (an unschooled mass concentrated in older cohorts and among women) and in **what a year of school delivers** (Morocco loses four years of schooling to weak learning).

And it is not what is blocking a transition. What blocks one is a single institutional fact: the effective chief executive is not chosen through elections.

The honest two-part conclusion:

1. **On feasibility.** No empirical basis exists for the claim that Morocco's education level forecloses democratisation. Spain democratised in 1978 with *less* schooling than Morocco has now.
2. **On quality.** The education deficit predicts the *kind* of democracy that would emerge — roughly 0.05 points below the median democratiser on the electoral index, with elevated exposure to clientelism and a female electorate whose political weight would fall far below its demographic weight. A quality penalty, not a barrier to entry.

II. Six findings that invert the intuition

1. Income was never the constraint — and it is the variable people worry about least accurately

The median country that democratised since 1960 did so at a GDP per capita of **$5,537** (Maddison, 2011 int$). Morocco's is **$8,400**. Two-thirds of all modern democratic transitions occurred in countries poorer than Morocco is today. India democratised at roughly $1,000, Benin at $1,790, Mali at $1,115.

This is not a contrarian reading of the literature — it *is* the literature. Przeworski and Limongi's central finding (1997) is that income does not raise the probability of a transition at all; it raises the probability that a democracy, once established, survives.

2. Spain democratised with less schooling than Morocco has today

The comparison that does the most damage to the "not ready" thesis is not East Asian. It is Iberian.

	Transition	GDP pc	Mean years of school	% adults with no schooling
Portugal	1976	$10,861	**3.5**	27 %
Brazil	1987	$8,402	**3.8**	26 %
Indonesia	1999	$5,187	**5.0**	27 %
Spain	**1978**	$13,569	**5.9**	**32 %**
MOROCCO	**today**	**$8,400**	**6.2**	**34 %**
South Korea	1988	$12,040	9.4	9 %
Taiwan	1996	$22,390	9.1	5 %

Spain and Portugal both produced consolidated liberal democracies — both score 0.82 on V-Dem's electoral democracy index today. **Korea and Taiwan sit in the top decile of the entire transition distribution.** Benchmarking Morocco against them and concluding "we are not ready" is benchmarking against the ceiling and mistaking it for the floor.

3. The astonishing one: Morocco does not have one electorate — it has two

This finding only appears when the adult population is disaggregated by age, which the standard datasets' 25-64 aggregate conceals entirely.

Moroccan cohort, 2025	% with no schooling	percentile at transition	Mean years	percentile
Aged 40–64	42.5 %	78th	4.9	30th
All adults 25+	34.5 %	72nd	6.0	44th
Aged 20–39	**10.4 %**	**38th**	**9.1**	**76th**

Moroccans under 40 are better schooled than three-quarters of all countries at the moment they democratised. At 9.1 years they sit between South Korea in 1988 (9.4) and Poland in 1990 (9.8) — precisely the benchmark assumed to be out of reach.

The national deficit is a **legacy stock**, held by cohorts that demographic replacement is retiring at a known rate: the 60+ cohort is 63 % unschooled, the 20–39 cohort 10 %. The education constraint on Moroccan democratisation is not structural. It is *expiring*.

4. Education is neither necessary nor sufficient — and two countries prove each half

- **Vietnam** scores **519** on the World Bank's harmonized learning outcome — higher than Spain (507) or Portugal (509) — with 10.7 learning-adjusted years of school and an education Gini of 0.26. Its electoral democracy index is **0.16**. Half a century of excellent mass education has produced no democratisation whatsoever. *Education is not sufficient.*
- **Senegal** has **2.9 years** of mean adult schooling and 67 % of adults unschooled — the most unequal education distribution in the comparator set. Its electoral democracy index is **0.61**, a functioning democracy that has survived repeated alternations of power. *Education is not necessary.*

Any argument that Morocco's schooling rules out democracy must explain Senegal. Any argument that schooling will deliver it must explain Vietnam.

5. Morocco is under-democratic relative to its own human capital — and it is not the oil

Regressing V-Dem's electoral democracy index on log income and mean schooling across 151 countries:

- Morocco's **predicted** score: **0.425**
- Morocco's **actual** score: **0.260**
- **Gap: −0.165** — the 38th largest democratic deficit in the world

This is regional, not idiosyncratic: the mean residual is **−0.30** across MENA against **+0.04** in the rest of the world. Tunisia is the only Arab country with a *positive* residual.

But Morocco's deficit cannot be explained by the standard resource-curse account. **Morocco's natural-resource rents are 0.4 % of GDP**, against 22.6 % in Algeria, 25.6 % in Saudi Arabia and 43.4 % in Iraq. *Morocco carries an Arab-sized democracy deficit without the Arab world's rents.*

6. Seventeenfold growth in schooling, zero regime change

Between 1950 and 2015 Morocco multiplied its adult schooling stock **seventeenfold** — from 0.3 to 5.1 years. Over the same period the V-Dem electoral democracy index moved from 0.05 to 0.26, and the regime classification never changed once.

V-Dem's *Regimes of the World* has coded Morocco a **closed autocracy in every single year from 1955 to 2025**. This is not a verdict on election quality. Under the coding rule, a closed autocracy is one where citizens cannot choose *either* the chief executive *or* the legislature in multiparty elections. Morocco elects its legislature. It is coded closed because the effective chief executive — the King — is not subject to election. That one institutional fact places Morocco in the same category as Saudi Arabia, while Algeria, Egypt and Iran are graded one step higher.

The 2011 constitutional reform moved the index by **+0.009**. Legislative turnout was 45.5 % (2011), 42.3 % (2016) and 50.4 % (2021).

III. What each table establishes

Table 1 — Morocco's position. GDP per capita $9,495 PPP (2025). Mean schooling 6.3 years for adults 25+ (HCP, RGPH 2024). Illiteracy 24.8 %, down from 32.2 % in 2014. Harmonized learning outcome 380. Learning-adjusted years of school 6.3 against 10.4 expected. Female labour-force participation 19.7 %. Electoral democracy index 0.259; regime code 0 (closed autocracy).

Table 2 — The transition distribution. Across 144 democratic transitions since 1960: median income at transition $5,537, median schooling 6.3 years, median unschooled share 13.7 %. Morocco's percentiles: **67.5 / 45.7 / 81.2**. The first two acquit Morocco; the third is the only indictment.

Table 3 — Eighteen benchmark transitions. Morocco today exceeds Portugal 1976, Brazil 1987, Indonesia 1999 and Spain 1978 on mean schooling, and sits below Korea 1988, Taiwan 1996, Poland 1990 and Chile 1990. The successful consolidations span the entire range, which is itself the finding.

Table 4 — The human-capital profile, 26 countries. Morocco's learning outcome (380) sits below Tunisia (384), Indonesia (395), India (399) and even Senegal (412). Its tertiary completion rate is 7.7 % while 42 % of adults had no schooling at all in 2015 — the elite-over-mass configuration in a single row.

Table 5 — Cross-country regression. Income alone explains 20 % of the variance in democracy; schooling alone 21 %; both together 22 %. Adding resource rents lifts it to 33 %, with rents entering significantly negative. Notably, **learning-adjusted years dominate income outright** (+0.043, t = 2.5, against +0.015, t = 0.4) — education *quality* carries the modernisation correlation better than either raw income or raw years.

Table 5b — The Arab democracy deficit. All sixteen MENA states except Tunisia score below prediction. Saudi Arabia is −0.61, Qatar −0.57, the UAE −0.56. Morocco's −0.17 makes it one of the *less* deficient Arab states — behind only Tunisia, Iraq and Lebanon.

Table 6 — Quality of democracy, among democracies only. Once a country is an electoral democracy,

income predicts liberal democracy, rule of law and freedom from corruption strongly ($R^2 \approx 0.50$); schooling predicts them strongly on its own but is absorbed by income when both enter. An honest negative result: the "education protects democratic quality" channel is weaker in the data than the theory suggests.

Table 7 — Within-country panel, 1960–2015, 161 countries. Pooled, lagged schooling raises democracy (+0.0068, t = 4.1). With country and period fixed effects the coefficient collapses to **+0.0011 (t = 0.2)** and income turns negative and insignificant. This replicates Acemoglu, Johnson, Robinson and Yared (2005, 2008) exactly, and it cuts both ways: it undercuts any claim that Morocco must first educate its way to democracy, and equally any claim that educating will deliver one.

Table 8 — Five independent sources on Morocco. Barro-Lee 5.11 years (2015); UNESCO UIS 4.94 (2017); Wittgenstein Centre 6.02 (2025); UNDP 6.20 (2023); HCP's own census **6.30** (2024). Every source converges on roughly six years. A methodological warning worth recording: **UIS's database is current to 2026, but its latest Moroccan observation is 2017** — for Morocco specifically, UIS is less current than Barro-Lee is stale.

Table 9 — Robustness. Re-running the entire transition benchmark on an independent dataset (Wittgenstein Centre, every country, every transition year) moves Morocco's mean-schooling percentile from 45.7 to 44.2 — no change — and the unschooled-share percentile from 81.2 to 71.7. The two datasets correlate at **r = 0.96** on the unschooled share across 141 countries. The conclusions do not turn on the data vintage.

Table 10 — The two electorates. The finding of §II.3, stated formally.

Two further results, not tabulated

- **Education at transition does not predict democratic survival.** Ten-year survival is 64 % overall and essentially flat across schooling terciles (62 % / 67 % / 61 %); a logit gives a coefficient of +0.015 with **p = 0.82**. Income is weakly positive (p = 0.11), exactly as Przeworski and Limongi predict.
- **It does predict the democracy *level* attained afterwards.** Mean electoral democracy over the decade following a transition rises by **+0.013 per year of schooling** (p = 0.003) and falls by **0.0017 per percentage point** of unschooled adults (p = 0.002). Applied to Morocco: a penalty of about **0.05** — real, but three times smaller than the 0.17 deficit already carried for institutional reasons.

IV. The gap analysis, stated plainly

Dimension	Morocco	Median at transition	Gap	Binding?
GDP per capita	$8,400	$5,537	**+$2,863 surplus**	No
Mean years of schooling	6.2	6.3	−0.1 years	No

Dimension	Morocco	Median at transition	Gap	Binding?
Adults with no schooling, 25+	34 %	17 %	+17 points	Yes — for quality
…aged 20–39	**10 %**	17 %	**−7 points surplus**	**No — already closed**
…aged 40–64	42 %	17 %	+25 points	Yes, but retiring
Learning quality (HLO)	380	∼430	**−50 points ≈ 1.5 school-years**	**Yes — for the next generation**
Elected chief executive	**No**	Yes, by construction	**Categorical**	**Yes — and it is the binding one**

The lever that closes the quality gap fastest is not more years — secondary enrolment is already near 90 % — but **learning per year of school**, and the **female schooling deficit in the 40+ cohorts**, which only demographic replacement and adult literacy programmes can reach.

The lever that closes the feasibility gap is not educational at all.

V. Limits

1. Barro-Lee v3 ends in 2015; the gender split and education Gini remain 2015 values. All headline figures have been re-estimated on Wittgenstein Centre data to 2025 and the benchmark re-run end to end.
2. Wittgenstein 2025 values are SSP2 projections from a 2020 base year, not observations — though they are driven almost entirely by cohorts already educated, so projection risk is small.
3. **The cohort result is about years, not learning.** The 20–39 cohort's 9.1 years are not 9.1 Korean years; Morocco's learning discount applies to them too. Convergence is in quantity only.
4. Transitions are identified from V-Dem's Regimes of the World. A Polity-based or Boix-Miller-Rosato coding would give a somewhat different event set.
5. All regressions are descriptive. None has a credible identification strategy; the fixed-effects panel is included precisely to show what survives when cross-sectional variation is removed.

VI. Key references

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Murtin & Wacziarg (2014), *JEG* 19(2): 141–181 — primary schooling, more than income, triggered the democratic transition 1870–2000.

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